equal treatment, upholding their distinctive identities and cultures and, importantly, their languages. If there was a preference, it was, not surprisingly, for the Manchu nobility, officials and soldiers. The Manchus organized themselves into ‘banners’, which were civil-military units with overall administrative and security functions. Originally there were eight banners, which were predominantly Manchu in composition but often included those Han military officials who had defected to the Manchus. In order to accommodate and to reward Han military officers who had defected to and were serving the Qing empire, a separate category called ‘Green Banners’ was created, but this would often include Manchu and Mongol elements. These banners were essentially grafted on to the Han bureaucracy but also served to monitor and check its activities. Some scholars have argued that the Qing ruled through a ‘conquest elite’ comprising the banner nobles and imperial kinsmen. They contest the notion that it was the Confucian literati that enabled Qing governance or that the language of this governance was overwhelmingly Chinese. A very large number of Manchu archives released recently support the view that the Manchu language was as much in use as an official language as was Chinese.

Chinese scholars argue that in order to rule China successfully, the Manchus had to Sinicize their empire, not only through the use of the Chinese language but through the promotion of Chinese literature, poetry and the arts. The Qing emperors were themselves poets and calligraphers in the Chinese language. The language of governance and of diplomacy was also Chinese after the initial phase of empire-building. While this may be true in respect of the predominantly Han areas of the empire, a different system prevailed in the non-Han areas, such as Manchuria, Mongolia, Tibet and Xinjiang. Here it was the ‘conquest elite’ which was in charge, and, as we have seen, the administrative structure was different. The Qing emperors would wish to portray themselves as Chinese rulers in the classical mould while dealing with their Han subjects, but would take on other appropriate identities while dealing with other ethnicities in the empire. Thus, for the Mongols the Qing emperor was the Khan of Khans, or the Bogdo Khan.